

Away From Home: All Academic and Non-academic Lessons Learnt

Ethnographic Narrative on
Life of a migrated student

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ANT 101: Introduction to Anthropology

BRAC University

09 May, 2021

Migration, a terminology standing for movement of people from one place to another, has several different reasons behind and occurs over varying extent. People usually move away from their place for valid and strong reasons; it is either following assurance of better work opportunities or after being officially transferred to another location from work, again, sometimes in search of better supplies and resources - such migration is what occurs under the influence of pull factor, triggered by an ensured goodness in the place to shift to. The other type, which is known to occur under the influence of the push factor, is when the place you are 'running away' from has serious safety issues or limited resources (National Geographic Society, 2015). Internal migration; moving within a state, country, or continent (National Geographic Society, 2015) occurs mostly under pull factors in countries such as ours. Thus, relocating in search of betterment is always justified.

However, what is it to move out of home or even hometown and arrive at a place one neither has any idea or experience of living at, nor does he/she have someone to take guidance or shelter from? That too, when someone in his/her early 20's, who hardly ever stayed away from the house and especially mother's care, shifts in order to study, jobless and without knowing anyone - how is it to survive in the fast moving city center coming from a small, distant town?

In this paper, we will try to look into it.

Public transport in Dhaka, if easily explained, is a rich collection of versatile people. There you will meet people of all ages, gender, type and culture. From little school kids to an old father; a cute, caring couple to a large, unmanageable family; an overstressed student to a chilling shopaholic; from a 9-5 office worker to physically tormented daily labour - all of them are different people of different types, leading very dissimilar lives, belonging to locations hundreds of kilometres apart, raised in varying societies, cultivated by separate ideologies and beliefs. Similarly, do their accents sound alike? Does everyone have the same behaviour and mentality when they sit or stand crammed inside a regular local bus on the busy roads of Dhaka? How many among these would willingly leave a seat for an aged or children? Does everyone behave alike to the contractor? No. Whereas, everyone in concern was tagged to belong to the same culture as a Bangali at birth!

Social behaviours are rarely similar in a bulk. A person's belief, mentality and expression depends complete upon what he/she grew up seeing, knowing and learning. If someone respects people of lower class than his, it's obvious that he was never taught to disgrace them, besides the beautiful thought of respecting everyone alike was strongly installed and practiced. These are places where one's culture and society matters, something that makes every person different from another.

When physical classes are open, I generally need to take a bus from my university to reach the crossroads, before catching another bus or, if too lavish to spend, an auto rickshaw to reach my required bus-stand. The first two parts of my four segment long journey back home. That first part is remarkable; surviving the life and death situation to somehow push myself up the stairs, swimming in-between the compact collection of static people in order to manage myself and my backpack a little space inside the bus to stand and breathe.

Inside, almost all the standing passengers are students, each and everyone proudly adorning their ribboned identity cards around their neck, making it easier to distinguish. Why won't they wear it! Students might miss wearing ID cards in respective colleges or universities, it is alright to be stopped at the entrance, but a complete 'No' to not paying the students' bus fees (50%) no matter how little you will save. After all it's our authorized right! The bus is a double decker one. Among the swarm of students targeting to get inside, the males are led upstairs while we girls have our little get together downstairs. As most of us are regular, it did not take us long to get familiar to each other's eye. This is where I met the character I chose to design this ethnographic research upon.

So, what is Ethnographic research?

According to Simpson & Coleman (2017), ethnography is the recording and analysis of a culture or society, usually based on participant-observation and resulting in a written account of a people, place or institution. It is a research method central to knowing the world from the standpoint of its social relations. Its qualitative research targets exploring the diversity of culture at home (wherever that may be) and abroad (Princeton University, n.d.). Through ethnography, we try to look into the lives of different types of people; try to know their origin, lifestyle and beliefs; analyse their economic management and thoughts on politics; thus, picturing how they visualise the world. Ethnography, basically, is an outsider's account on how it is to live as someone else inside the latter's society and culture. It involves hands-on, on-the-scene learning — and it is relevant wherever people are relevant; thus can be done at every level (Princeton University, n.d.).

Unlike the primitive idea about anthropology, ethnography does not necessarily need the character or culture in question to be completely unfamiliar and distant, it can be on anyone, from any country or locality. As we know, there are several subcultures within a culture, and people usually do not know much in-details beyond their own. So, reading such an account of ethnography helps people learn and know all that is unexplored and unknown- from a vast culture located miles away in a different

part of the world to something as simple as the group of people residing in the next lane. Although ethnography is the major tool of social and cultural anthropology, it attained many of its methods from other branches of humanities and natural science (Princeton University, n.d.). So, not only the writing contains information of many different types, the background work, as in the research part behind the write-up, also needs to be versatile in order to fulfill different demands.

Now, there are several ways to do the research. Besides secondary research to gather background information on the particular society or culture the researcher targets, ethnography requires and is mostly based upon primary research, which, to specify, consists of careful participant observation and interviews. Once the researcher decides on which specific issue to work on, he has a vast option of research methodology to choose from. If the research is based upon a specific family/clan the research needs to follow genealogical method (long term study of family line); if the researcher wishes to solve any problem through the research, his questionnaire would be designed accordingly; to write about the gradual change over time, the researcher gets to choose longitudinal research method; whereas working with a person's life history (getting the account of everything he experienced over time and considering all his interpretations) the researcher can experience a little time travel in the lanes of local history. Society based researches brings bunches of local beliefs to deal with, their emics¹ and etics². And when with a vast sample to interview and interact with, it is best to form a team with different strengths and make the bulk stand strong together. All these allow the researcher to experience and decide what's exactly going on. He is free to use his perspective and point of view to analyse the culture and system, even the things which people inside a society generally do not question about. After all, interviews play just a supporting role in ethnographic narrative, something of proof to back up the researchers' written words. However, this idea of perspective may backfire if the writer gets biased. This is one of the several limitations of such

¹ The local cultural beliefs.

² The scientific explanation behind the behaviour, which might not always be accepted by the society.

researches. As the narrative is jotted down by the researcher, from his interpretation and perspective, no theories can be centrally concluded out of it. A sense of authority might act when people are interviewed, and actual opinion might not always be received, which makes it less reliable. Moreover, the process is so long and time consuming, it becomes very difficult to recheck for the validity of conclusions stated.

Among the above mentioned methods, my study comes as a mixture of both quantitative and qualitative research. This account is based mostly upon observation and semi-structured interviews where a little research through secondary resources helped finding the information requested.

Rehnuma is an undergraduate student under the Social Science Department of Bangladesh University of Textiles. We met almost everyday during those 15 mins travel in the student crammed bus. Although not intentional, she almost always caught my eyes; a well-mannered girl of my age whose total appearance looks a bit shabbier for the trinket of intelligence and goodliness that reflects through her eyes. In all those days of travel, neither I ever found her raising her voice nor saw her getting impatient as we stood in the intolerable gathering and exhausting condition inside the bus. And to my wonder, never a single word against the traffic in the streets of Dhaka! How can someone be so calm and considerate?

Within a week or two, we started acknowledging each other's presence, just a little smile or maybe just direct eye contacts. Thus, without any intention and preplanning, my report building session for this paper was successfully done.

On one such day, as the bus seemed to fall asleep in the immobile traffic on the roads, few changes in positions brought Rehnuma right beside me. That's when we first talked, greeted and shared names. As the traffic constrained, our conversation proceeded. She comes from a town located in the

district Moulvibazar, Sylhet and stays in a shared apartment with four of her classmates in Tejgaon. Similarly, we met again, and several times more in the bus. Slowly, our conversation proceeded.

Rehnuma, along with her mother and younger sister, lives at her maternal grandparents' place. They shifted there about two years ago as just after her SSC examination, Rehnuma's father married his friend's sister. With the deepest sigh she explained how hard it had been to live at her grandparents' tolerating the daily dose of taunts from her Mami³ and mocking sympathy from the neighbors. Secretly, she seemed pleased over the fact that she does not need to hear those here in Dhaka. But thinking of what her mother and sister must be facing terrorizes her. She also shared that with the money she received as scholarship after her SSC examination, Rehnuma bought her mother a sewing machine. Since then she works as a tailor, in contract with the shrines, supplying them with the flags and drapes required. The little much she earns from it is enough to pay for running her sister's studies. Her father does not even care to ask how they are managing to carry out everything in day to dayout lives. Rehnuma's younger sister was a student of class seven back then.

Rehnuma might have read the arc of curiosity in my mind, because she came up with the answer right before I would have asked why she would take the trouble to travel Mohakhali from Tejgaon, almost daily, given that she has no friends or relatives here. In cities like Dhaka, everything is way more expensive than smaller towns. As she aimed not to take money from her grandfather or uncle to live and study here in Dhaka, she requires to arrange it on her own. Thus she took up two tuitions which keeps her at work all six days out of seven in a week. With the earned money, as she said, Rehnuma is able to pay the apartment's rent, the one-fifth of her share and bear the cost of food and transport. In her words, "I never used a car back in Sylhet so moving around in public transport is not a problem. The rickshaw fare is extremely high. I have no other option than to travel by bus if the distance is too long for a walk." As she further explained, "It's true that I can not afford fast food, or

³ The wife of the maternal uncle.

anything from restaurants. It gets very hard to buy the monthly required rations. We purchase these on sharing. You can not expect to cook the same thing 5 different times!" As she continued to say, "I need to travel outside, to class and tuition everyday, this requires a lot of dresses. I managed to save some money in a few months then bought a handful of three-pieces, but all cheap enough not to lose its good-looks in a couple of months. Mother stitched them for free. I need to buy a few before I visit Sylhet again." I thought what it might be to face all the struggle so early in one's life, how simply they need to decide upto what extent their reach is limited to.

As our communication continued, I noticed her discomfort in travelling through public transports, and the difference in her accent. In her explanation the rickshaw fare here in Dhaka is immeasurably high but surprisingly the buses are too cheap for the distances travelled. She added, "Considering the immensity of Dhaka I don't really feel as secure as I do back at my home town. The public bus drivers are quite aggressive on the road. Given the fact that I still don't know this city well, I'm always on the edge when I'm on public transport worried if an accident might occur or if someone might try to rob me. I'm always worried about it, I haven't experienced harassment of any kind. Although there is a huge safety issue when boarding and getting off a public transport."

Another day, as she was showing me some pictures of one of her classmate's birthday party, "Food in Dhaka is a lot more elevated and delicious than Sylhet but so is the cost. The variety and range of food in Dhaka is much wider than in Sylhet. However, without a doubt Sylhet has ridiculously good food at very cheap price tags but try finding the same quality in Dhaka and your pockets will definitely be drained. I was stunned seeing the bill that day!" Later she added, "People in Sylhet prefer home and comfort food instead of fast foods and exotic cuisines. On the other hand Dhaka is quite versatile when it comes to choice of cuisines. Japanese, Chinese, Mexican, etc. it's all here. Going out and eating at restaurants is more normal than eating at home in Dhaka. The restaurant culture here is a completely different world. While I tried to enjoy this new and exciting side to this

massive city I missed the homemade food of my mother. I don't go out too much when in Sylhet so I always eat at home and my mother is an exceptional cook. So everytime I eat in Dhaka I miss her cooking no matter what the dish is." I could see tears glittering in the corner of her eyes. To change the topic I snapped with a question to ask what used to be her local favourite food, "Bakhorkahni, it's like a sweat paratha."

Well, people in Dhaka know a different food in the same name though!

One such day, we were stuck in traffic for so long that we decided to walk up to the crossroads. For the first time I noticed some change in her expressions. We passed a pair of our aged girl and a boy walking side by side each holding a cigarette between their fingers. She rushed past them so fast that it was apparent how uncomfortable she was with the ideas, if not with the closeness of boys and girls but surely with the girl smoking. Later I asked her how the surrounding of the area she lives in is, how their neighbours are. As she lives in an industrial area, most houses are booked by either workers or students like them. "It's more like a hostel. Everyone is on the run early in the morning. We do not get to communicate much with the neighbors too." She also explained how hard it is becoming for her to manage classes, students, houseworks and her studies in addition to the traffic of Dhaka. "I didn't know how to cook or wash my clothes which obviously became a major issue when you're living alone. We cook in a batch and eat for 3-4 days. We clean our house only on the weekends. Even the laundry, all the clothes of the week remain piled until I get time to wash them on Fridays. Now you can not imagine keeping a maid to help you here. I literally learnt everything on my own coming here. How I wish mother was here."

Lastly, to finalize my materials for this paper, I contacted her over the phone. She informed me last year she was stuck in Dhaka for three months because of Covid-19 and had her first Ramadan and Eid without her mother and sister. When I asked what it was that she missed the most during her stays in Dhaka, Rehnuma snapped saying, "I missed my room which was a lot larger than the one in

Dhaka. I missed how I casually sit in our brands with mother and grandmother or watch television with them. I missed the terrace of our house, my garden up there. I missed waking up to not worrying about getting my laundry done or what I was supposed to eat that day because I was always blessed with good food at home. And of course I missed my family."

And what did you do to fit in the city life and culture here in Dhaka? "I got used to catching public transport without dying. Learnt calculating non-rush hour times to find space in transports. Thus, I changed my schedule around that. I got used to long rides and a lot of traffic, heat and pollution. Even, I started using masks before the COVID-18 crisis because the air pollution in Dhaka was literally hurting my nostrils.", Rehnuma ended.

Yes, she never belonged here. To her, the city should have fresh air to breathe, houses should have terraces to walk around and do gardening on, not to open a rooftop restaurant. To her, people must crave to eat food made by one's mother, not that by an unknown chef. Yet she held up a smile and fought, tried making herself used to the city culture. Missed her family, yet held tight. Few reasons why I found a migrated student just 200 kilometres away, within the borders of the country.

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